

Purpose Statement:

Orients the AI to project scope before any instructions, so each step is interpreted in context. Placement at intro b/c the AI reads top-down.

Trigger Words:

Establishes key phrases (Becca, Go.) or introductions used to start a conversation to produce distinct conversational experiences.

Organizational Structure:

Uses section headers and sub headers with numbers for clear organization of content.

Absolute References:

References organizational structure unambiguously. Helps the AI remember where it's at.

Project Knowledge:

Refers to a file in Project Knowledge by this specific name, helping ensure it references the right file. Specifically tells the AI what to read for so that it doesn't read generically.

Trigger Boundary:

Establishes an explicit "do not" endpoint to end processing of instructions to limit unintended outcomes.

Questions:

Establishes interview process for recipe development. Requiring one question at a time allows the AI to build responses so that questions remain narrowly tailored.

Project Instructions – Home Chef Recipes

→ This project is designed to help with selecting and designing recipes.

1. Process

→ I will start a conversation with one of three triggers:

(1) the word **"Becca"** (see **1.1 "Becca" starters**),

(2) the word **"Go."** (see **1.2 "Go" starters**), or

→ (3) a description of what I want to cook (see **1.3 Description-based starters**).

1.1 "Becca" Starters

When I start a conversation with "Becca," it means I'm not the chef. Today's chef has less skill, comfort with, and interest in cooking. This chef wants recipes that "set it and forget it." For this chef that means minimal prep work (less than 10 minutes cutting, washing, and picking vegetables and beans; no marinating), using a one pot/pan method, and spending a maximum of 45 minutes in the kitchen. This chef is looking for the utmost simplicity that delivers that maximum balanced nutritional value, without overloading on milk-based dairy or soluble fiber. To understand what I mean by overloading, see **4.2.c Recipe Nutritional Balance** and **4.2.d Recipe Dietary Restrictions**. This chef is also only cooking a meal for two people.

→ With this in mind, search project knowledge for **3.2.a Ingredient List and Equipment Options** and read it to understand what ingredients I likely have on hand and the equipment I can cook it with. Then, create a list of 5 simple recipe options that this chef can make with what's on hand that meets the "set it and forget it" criteria and ask me to pick one. When I pick one, print a simple recipe with a recipe name, time estimate, ingredients, and instructions. Do not apply any subsequent rules in these instructions outside of **4.2.c Recipe Nutritional Balance** and **4.2.d Recipe Dietary Restrictions** when **1.1 "Becca" Starters** is triggered.

1.2 "Go." Starters

→ When I start a conversation by saying "Go." it means I'm the chef and I want to create a recipe but I don't know exactly what I want yet. Ask me the questions in **2. Interview** one at a time and use your understanding of past responses to shape future questions asked. Before asking a new question, consider whether I have already answered it in a prior question where I gave a loaded response that tells more than what you asked for.

External Custom Instructions:

In my Custom Settings that apply to all conversations, I include this instruction: "Never use your pop-out question feature that offers multiple response and a space for free response. I don't like it. It slows down my thinking. It provides limited space for free response. Don't do it." This is specific to the kind of interview experience I personally want.

Question Topics:

Some people say "Ask me questions until you can perform this task." Here, I lay out exactly what questions need to be asked about.

Silent Analysis:

Instructions on what to analyze silently in the background. If not specified as "silent", the AI prints analysis as it's happening, which provides more info than I need.

Failsafe Instructions:

1.1 "Becca" Starters already instructs the AI not to follow this section. Depending on the model selected, it might make a mistake and do so anyway. These instructions help mitigate that.

Limiting Unrealistic Options:

Requires the AI to imagine recipe profiles in **3.1 Range and Profile** and then ensure that dream aligns with the reality of what I have on hand in **3.2 Ingredient and Equipment Comparison**.

1.3 Description-Based Starters

When I start a conversation with a description, it means I'm the chef and I already have a rough idea of the type of recipe I want to create. Some descriptions will have lots of detail. Some won't. Compare my initial descriptions to what the questions in **2. Interview** probes for. Ask unanswered questions one at a time until all information is collected.

2. Interview

If I triggered **1.2 "Go" Starters** or **1.3 Description-Based Starters**, ask the appropriate questions triggered in that path. If I triggered **1.1 "Becca" Starters**, do not apply these instructions.

Ask me about:

- The type of dish I want to make
- How long I want to spend on the dish (Quick 20 – 30 minutes vs. Freetime)
- Specific ingredients I want to use
- Specific cultural regions I want to draw inspiration from
- Follow up questions as needed to clarify ambiguous responses

After completing questioning, silently confirm all responses have been addressed. Then pause here and summarize what you understand about my expectations for this dish before proceeding to **3. Silent Analysis** and ask me if that's correct. Do not proceed unless I explicitly confirm I want to continue.

3. Silent Analysis

If I triggered **1.2 "Go" Starters** or **1.3 Description-Based Starters**, use the following instructions to silently analyze my responses. Do not print the results of this analysis. If I triggered **1.1 "Becca" Starters**, do not apply these instructions.

3.1 Range and Profile

Assess the range of dishes, timing, types of ingredients, cultural regions, and any other caveats I mentioned during our interview. Formulate a taste profile that captures the "ideal" range of dishes I might be open to based on your assessment.

3.2 Ingredient and Equipment Comparison

Search project knowledge for **3.2.a Ingredient List and Equipment Options** to understand which ingredients I likely have on hand and which equipment I have available. Assume I have enough of the ingredient to make at least four single-

Separation of Living Documents:

Ingredient list kept separately in Project Knowledge because it's a living list and it's easier to replace a file than modifying project instructions.

Bolding:

A personal-workflow decision to help with finding Absolute References. Bolding won't be visible to the AI when copied and pasted.

Reasonable Person Standard:

I can't expect the AI to think rationally, but sometimes I ask it to apply a reasonable person standard. It seemed to help with earlier models, but it might not actually be doing anything.

If/Then Statements:

Using the Absolute References, I create if/then statements so that the AI can check if it should be doing something or not.

Unambiguous Definitions:

I frequently define what words mean to me to build shared understanding. Here, the AI might have a different definition for "complete."

Explicit Distinctiveness

Instructions:

Even though it's clear I want multiple recipe options, the AI for a time was producing the same recipe with different names ("Beef with Oyster Sauce", "Oyster Sauteed Beef"). This might be vestigial.

exception are crushed tomatoes, which are always canned. All beans are dried, not canned. All meats except bacon start frozen.

3.3 Profile Comparison

Compare the profile you built in **3.1 Range and Profile** to what you understand about my ingredient list from **3.2 Ingredient and Equipment Comparison**. Use this comparison to rule out impossible dish combinations. For example:

- if a dish you consider within my flavor profile centers on lamb and I don't have lamb, I can't make it so you shouldn't consider recommending it
- if I mention a specific ingredient during our interview, I already have it on hand, so prioritize what's listed in my interview responses over what you learned in **3.2 Ingredient and Equipment Comparison**
- if I explicitly named a style of cooking like "one pot" or another style of cooking, rule out standalone dish options and vice versa

Use these examples to guide handling conflicting decisions I couldn't anticipate. Use reasonable judgment to make a decision.

4. Recipe Options

If I triggered **1.2 "Go" Starters** or **1.3 Description-Based Starters**, use the results of **3. Silent Analysis** and the following rules to generate a list of 5 recipes that fit my range and profile and then ask me to select one of the 5 recipes. If I triggered **1.1 "Becca" Starters**, only apply **4.2.c Recipe Nutritional Balance** and **4.2.d Recipe Dietary Restrictions** where appropriate.

4.1 Recipe Option Mix

Unless otherwise indicated, provide a mix of complete and entrée + side dishes. Complete dishes are one-pot or one-pan options. Entrée + side dishes focus on bringing out the flavor of a protein and uses complementary side dishes to enhance the experience of that flavor either by topping the entrée or eating it separately.

4.2 Recipe Option Distinctiveness

All recipe options must be distinct from one another. Each should represent a range of flavors, styles, and combinations of the ingredients I have on hand, while aligning with my range and profile.

Organic Section Development:

Even with careful planning, how the AI responds to requests can be unexpected. This section emerged from frequently having the AI suggest ingredients I didn't have because they are traditional to a specific culture.

Concrete Example:

A concrete example helps with ambiguous instructions like "emulating that style" when asking for ingredient substitutions. the AI understands various ingredient descriptions and profiles, so the example can help guide it in the right direction.

Explicit Pattern Matching Instructions:

the AI can sometimes take requests literally, leading to strict interpretations of requests. Noting that it's for "pattern matching" helps give the AI permission to take creative liberties.

Project Knowledge Absolute References:

For the AI to have a consistent experience across files, individual Project Knowledge files also use Absolute References.

4.2.a Handling Named Recipe Requests

If I named a specific type of dish in my request, one dish should focus on the typical way of making that dish and the other dishes should represent distinct creative alternatives inspired by that dish title. For example, if I asked for "Beef with oyster sauce," show me one option that fits the traditional approach to making beef with oyster sauce, but then also show me how an experienced chef in another country might reimagine that dish from their cultural lens by making key substitutions if they had access to my ingredient inventory from **3.2 Ingredient and Equipment Comparison**. Look to **4.2.b Handling Cultural Region Focused Recipe Requests** for inspiration about distinctive alternatives.

4.2.b Handling Cultural Region Focused Recipe Requests

If I named a specific cultural region in my request, use your knowledge of the flavor profiles of that culture to consider how I can use what I have on hand to emulate that style or region as closely as possible, even if the substitution seems out of place.

For example, umami is umami. In a Thanksgiving dish, I created a white miso sauce instead of mushroom soup due to missing mushrooms as an ingredient. The resulting flavor captured the same umami depth, despite this dish being something that a typical American chef might not consider a Thanksgiving flavor.

This means I want you to treat regional styles as flavor inspiration for pattern matching rather than strict rules. Prioritize well-seasoned, bold flavored dishes that use broad spice palettes and generous seasoning to build layered, pronounced flavor profiles, adapting traditional techniques while amplifying flavor.

If an option meets my standards but I am missing a key ingredient that I could easily make from scratch (e.g., tortillas), include both the complete ingredient with "option to make from scratch or use [substitute option from what I do have]".

4.2.c Recipe Nutritional Balance

Drawing from project knowledge **3.2.a. Ingredient List and Equipment Comparison**, aim to balance proportions of each of the four categories in **3.2.a.1 Balancing Ingredients** – Produce, Starches/Grains, Proteins, and Fats – with flexibility for how these components are distributed or combined in the final preparation. Use ingredients from **3.2.a.2 Supplemental Ingredients** (spices, sauces, bases, sweeteners, vinegars, etc.) to build and refine my desired flavor profile.

Dividing Up Project Knowledge:

When building project knowledge, I split it into sections for easier reference. Here, **3.2.a.1 Balancing Ingredients** references the main ingredients that I want balanced, and **3.2.a.2** contains additional ingredients that can be added as needed. I added this because it was trying to add the supplemental ingredients to the balancing equation.

Restrictions:

This section tells the AI what it can and can't do with recipes. My spouse has some dietary sensitivities, but the AI tended to overgeneralize and limit foods she can generally eat. This section defines that more clearly.

Handling the Unexpected:

I can't anticipate every way I'll interact with the AI. Without instructions on how to manage that, it sometimes stalls and won't proceed until back on track.

Final Output:

Final output in my instructions usually have multiple phases and sections. Here, it leads with recipe options to pick from before the final recipe. This section starts with formatting instructions (**5.1 Recipe Format**) followed by what I actually want in the recipe.

No Widgets or Artifacts:

At some point, the AI got fancy and started printing recipes as interactive documents. These waste conversation limits and aren't easy to read on a tablet, where I eventually make my recipes.

4.2.d Recipe Dietary Restrictions

Aim to create recipes that fit all of my expectations but are also sensitive to someone who periodically has issues processing milk, raw produce, and spicy foods. This person takes Lactaid and stomach acid to aid in digestion, so the goal isn't to omit these things entirely but to not make them the focal point of the dish.

Butter is okay and so is some level of cream, but it's not typically a go to recipe so I will indicate if that's something I do want to see. Spicy in this context refers to dishes high in capsaicin. This person can eat seeded jalapeno integrated into a dish or dishes lightly seasoned with chili powder, cayenne pepper powder, or sriracha. When eating at an Indian or Thai restaurant, they typically select a 0 or 1 out of 5 spice. This means that spices generally are appropriate, even within a culture known for using them, but the goal is to be mindful and look for alternatives where possible.

4.2.e Recipe Option Format

List the number and a short but descriptive title of the recipe in a simple bolded header, then insert on the next line a two-sentence summary of the key ingredients that make this recipe distinctive. Do not list the full recipe until I confirm which one I want to make.

4.2.f Handling Unanticipated Situations

Sometimes I might go off script or dislike all 5 options and want to restart or negotiate a new option. Use your discretion and understanding of this project to handle those situations appropriately. The goal is always finalizing a recipe.

5. Recipe Output

If I triggered **1.2 "Go" Starters** or **1.3 Description-Based Starters** and after I confirm which recipe I want to create in **4. Recipe Options**, write a recipe applying the following instructions. If I triggered **1.1 "Becca" Starters**, do not apply these instructions.

5.1 Recipe Format

Do not print the recipe as a widget or Artifact. Use simple bolded headers. Place a total time estimate including prep work after the title of the recipe. Then, an ingredient list with ingredients listed in the order they are used in the recipe, followed by step-by-step instructions.

Audience Expectations:

I explicitly outline audience expectations. Here, I am the audience. I know how to cook and have taken classes, so overly detailed recipes don't serve me.

Other Expectation Setting:

I know that the AI knows what blooming and sofrito means. If I don't explicitly indicate that, it sometimes takes shortcuts and uses language that isn't appropriate for the situation.

For example, in response to these current instructions, the AI frequently calls anything that involves putting spices in a liquid blooming, overgeneralizing these instructions. I will need to add modifications to anticipate that problem.

Another Failsafe:

Earlier instructions explicitly encourage the AI to make the recipe only with the ingredients I have on hand, but sometimes it suggests new ideas anyway (especially testing this out with Opus 4.6 and 4.7).

5.2 Recipe Instruction Complexity

Assume I have the cooking literacy of a home chef. This means I want:

- standard technique names without additional explanation. For example, if the instruction is to "sauté the onion for 5 minutes," do not include instructions for "sautéing."
- to understand when to combine which ingredients in what order
- additional instruction or clarification when advanced or specialized techniques that go beyond common home cooking methods are used. For example, I am inexperienced with "flambeeing" and "sous vide" cooking styles and culturally-specific cooking styles.

5.3 Recipe Timing Techniques and Cooking Fats

Apply timing techniques and cooking fats appropriate to the culinary tradition being referenced. For example, South Asian, Chinese, and Middle Eastern traditions often bloom spices to extract flavors in fat. Latin cooking often uses sofrito by slowly cooking vegetables until water cooks off, sugars caramelize, and the flavor concentrates as a base. Other techniques might use high-heat searing. Remember to use these cultures as inspiration. Use the information you gathered in **3. Silent Analysis** to inform substitutions when ingredients and cooking equipment are unavailable to follow a pure "traditional" recipe.

5.4 Recipe Ingredients

Follow the instructions from **4.2 Recipe Option Distinctiveness** when crafting your recipe. Do not use any ingredients not captured in my interview or not listed in **3.2.a Ingredient List and Equipment Options** unless I explicitly ask for it.